



Granite

△ **Classic pink granite** containing quartz, feldspar, and mica

Familiar as a mottled pink, white, grey, and black ornamental stone, granite is the most common intrusive rock in the Earth’s continental crust. Granite’s three main minerals are feldspar, quartz, and muscovite, or biotite mica. Of the three principal minerals, feldspar predominates, and quartz (see pp.132–39) usually accounts for more than 10 per cent. Granite has been a favourite stone for carving and building for at least four millennia. Wherever it has been available, its strength and durability have made it a first choice for everything from temples to millstones.

Specification

Rock type Felsic, plutonic, igneous | **Major minerals** Potassium feldspar, quartz, mica, sodium | **Minor minerals** Sodium plagioclase, hornblende | **Colour** White, light grey, grey, pink, red | **Texture** Medium to coarse



Granite host | Rough | Granites are often host to a variety of gemstones – this granite groundmass is covered in tourmaline crystals.



Granodiorite | Rough | Commercial “granites” come in a range of colours and textures, depending on their exact makeup. This specimen tends toward granodiorite.



Boulder with microcline | Rough | This granite boulder takes its pink colour from the large amount of microcline feldspar that comprises its makeup.



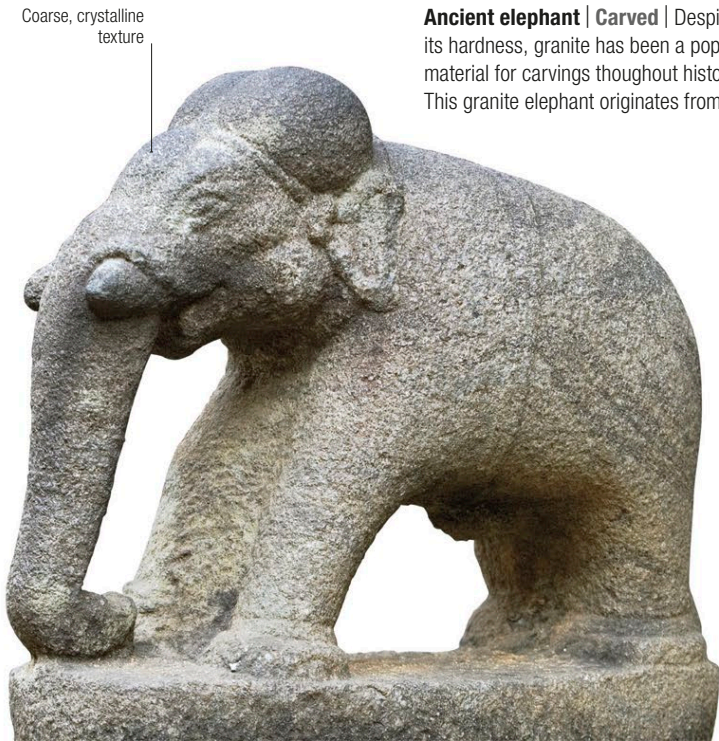
Commercial granite | Cut | This sample of kitchen worktop material is commercially sold as “white granite”, but is closer to granodiorite in makeup.



Granite bead | Carved | The patterns of granite fascinated ancient civilizations, which created carvings such as this bead. The black portion is hornblende.



“Black granite” | Cut | This sample of kitchen worktop material is commercially sold as “black granite”, although in reality its composition is closer to diorite.



Ancient elephant | Carved | Despite its hardness, granite has been a popular material for carvings throughout history. This granite elephant originates from India.